



Combat Mindset Conditioning

AN ARMY TRAINING PRODUCT WITHIN THE ARMY COMBAT MINDSET SYSTEM

Army Command School

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Purpose

Combat Mindset Conditioning (CMC) is the deliberate practice of an individual's capacity to regulate and sustain effective performance under operational pressure. It provides a structured method for developing Combat Mindset.

Combat Mindset: the capacity to regulate and sustain effective performance under operational pressure.

CMC is nested within the Army Combat Mindset System (ACMS) and supports its developmental pathway: **Understand Self → Regulate Self → Perform Under Pressure → Combat Mindset.**

Its purpose is not simply to teach individuals about pressure. It is to progressively condition the capacity to recognise, regulate and sustain performance as pressure and operational demands increase.

1. Training Pillars

CMC develops the underlying capacities required to maintain performance under pressure. The initial architecture draws directly from the six existing COGCON pillars.

Pillar	What it develops
Self-Awareness	Recognise changes in physiological, cognitive and emotional state.
Arousal Control	Regulate physiological activation to maintain access to effective performance.
Operational Habit	Develop effective responses that remain available as conscious capacity reduces under pressure.
Working Memory	Retain and manipulate relevant information while operating under load.
Attentional Control	Direct, maintain and shift attention appropriately despite distraction, pressure and threat.
Cognitive Control	Inhibit ineffective responses and retain deliberate control over behaviour and decisions.

COGCON doctrine already treats these as interdependent capacities and specifies a sequence beginning with self-awareness and arousal control as the foundation for downstream cognitive performance.

- **Army design requirement:** determine whether the six pillars are adopted directly, adapted into Army terminology, consolidated or supplemented.

2. Operational Reset Tool

CMC provides the individual with a simple, repeatable method for recovering performance when regulation begins to degrade under pressure. The tool enables the individual to: **Recognise → Regulate → Reorient → Re-engage.**

COGCON provides an existing Operational Reset Tool designed to be applied independently and under load. Its mechanism incorporates appraisal of state, perceptual reorientation, physiological modulation and re-anchoring attention onto the next relevant action. The detailed reset sequence is retained within the COGCON Master Doctrine and accredited coaching material rather than reproduced in the Phase 2 discussion paper.

- **Army design requirement:** work with Ken Franks to develop or adapt an Army-owned reset tool and associated terminology within the agreed IP arrangements.

3. Performance Standards

CMC requires performance to be observable under pressure, not simply understood theoretically. COGCON currently uses four Operational Performance States (OPS4), which give coaches observable indicators of whether regulation and performance are being sustained as pressure increases.

Performance state	Observable indicators
Performance Mindset	Task focus and deliberate action.
Command Presence	Controlled posture, communication and pacing.
Situational Awareness	Active scanning, information gathering and resistance to fixation.
Resilience	Rapid recovery following error, correction or performance disruption.

- **Army design requirement:** determine the CMC performance standards and behavioural markers. These may be derived from OPS4 but should ultimately describe the behaviours Army expects to observe from its people under operational pressure.

4. Training Methodology

CMC is conditioning through deliberate practice, not simply education about stress or cognition. Training progresses from understanding and practising the component skills in controlled conditions toward their application under increasingly representative pressure: **Understand** → **Practise** → **Pressure** → **Apply** → **Reinforce**.

Pressure is introduced progressively through physical, cognitive, emotional, environmental and task demands appropriate to the training context.

CMC does not need to exist solely as a standalone course. Once foundational skills have been taught, they can be deliberately practised and reinforced within existing Army training. COGCON argues explicitly for this approach: conditioning should occur within existing training, under the load that training already generates, rather than remaining a separate classroom activity. This allows CMC to be reinforced through PT, leadership training, field exercises and other individual and collective training as the system matures. The ACMS already anticipates this model of deliberate instruction followed by continued practice and application.

5. Coaching and Assessment

CMC uses trained coaches and instructors to **observe** → **identify** → **intervene** → **reset** → **reassess**.

Assessment therefore focuses on whether the individual can demonstrate the required behaviours while under appropriate pressure, rather than simply recalling CMC knowledge.

COGCON provides a useful starting model: Level 1 Coach, Level 2 Coach and Specialist, supported by observed assessment, recertification and quality assurance. CMC does not necessarily need to replicate those tiers.

- **Army design requirement:** determine an instructor model that fits existing Army instructor qualification, assurance and training-management systems.

6. Progressive Development

CMC directly supports the four-stage Army Combat Mindset developmental pathway.

Stage	Step	CMC contribution
1. Understand Self	Recognise your response.	Introduces self-awareness and understanding of individual responses to pressure.
2. Regulate Self	Control that response.	Develops practical regulation skills and the operational reset tool.
3. Perform Under Pressure	Sustain performance under pressure.	Progressively conditions those capabilities under increasing and varied forms of load.
4. Combat Mindset	Apply it to operational demands.	Integrated into representative military training so the individual practises maintaining effective performance under increasingly realistic operational demands.

7. Delivery and Assurance

CMC should be capable of both formal instruction and distributed reinforcement. Initially, specialist CMC instructors deliver foundational training and develop Army instructor capability. As proficiency develops, trained instructors and commanders reinforce CMC through existing training environments.

A defined assurance system protects: **training sequence · instructor competence · pressure progression · reset-tool integrity · behavioural standards · assessment consistency.**

This is an area where COGCON gives Army a significant head start. Its existing architecture already contains coach accreditation, recertification, quality assurance and drift control.

Product Architecture

The elements above form a product architecture rather than a collection of techniques.

Element	Role in the product
Training pillars	What we develop.
Operational reset tool	What the individual can do when performance degrades.
Performance standards	What we observe.
Training methodology	How we condition all of it so it remains accessible under pressure.

Sources and Status

Derived from the COGCON Phase 2 Discussion Document (Ken Franks) and the Army Combat Mindset System one-pager (Army Command School, 2026). Elements derived from COGCON are subject to adaptation and to the IP arrangements agreed with Ken Franks. The Army design requirements above identify the elements Army still needs to design and endorse.